

4x4
SAR

Emergency Signal Quick Reference

S.T.O.P., stay put, and signal clearly.

IF YOU'RE LOST: S.T.O.P.

S — SIT DOWN Stop moving. Panic is your enemy. Every wrong step takes you farther from where rescuers will look.

T — THINK When did you last know your location? Can you retrace your steps safely and confidently?

O — OBSERVE Landmarks, trail markers, sounds of roads or water. Check your map and compass carefully.

P — PLAN If unsure, STAY PUT. Make yourself visible and signal for help. We search your planned route first.

#1 RULE: STAY PUT 80% of lost hikers are found within 1 mile of their last known position — when they don't wander. Moving makes it exponentially harder to find you.

AUDIO SIGNALS

- Whistle (BEST): 3 short blasts, pause, repeat. Heard up to 1 mile. Uses almost no energy. Always carry one.
- Voice: Shout 'HELP' in groups of 3. Cup hands, aim toward sounds. Save your voice — a whistle is 10x better.

VISUAL SIGNALS

- Signal mirror: Flash toward aircraft/ridgelines. Visible up to 10 miles on clear day. Any shiny surface works.
- Bright colors: Spread gear in open areas. Wave bright items overhead when you hear or see searchers.
- Fire / smoke: Fire visible at night; smoke during day. Add green branches for white smoke. 3 fires in triangle = SOS.
- Ground symbols: Make 10+ ft tall, high contrast to ground. X = need medical help. V = need assistance. SOS = distress.

ELECTRONIC + SATELLITE

- Cell phone: Try 911 even with no bars — connects via ANY carrier. Text 911 if voice call fails.
- Satellite 911 texting: FREE for all carriers via T-Mobile/Starlink (emergency 911 only). Full messaging: \$10/mo.
- iPhone 14+ SOS: Built-in satellite SOS, no subscription. Practice: Settings > Emergency SOS > Try Demo.
- Android SOS: Pixel 9+, Galaxy S25+ support satellite emergency messaging via phone settings.
- Garmin inReach: Two-way satellite texting + SOS with 24/7 monitoring center. ~\$15/mo subscription.
- Battery saving: Airplane mode between 911 attempts. Reduce brightness. Texting uses less power than calls.

FREE Satellite 911 (all carriers) Garmin inReach Mini 2 <https://www.t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-servi> <https://www.garmin.com/en-US/p/765374>



Satellite 911 Signup

t-mobile.com/satellite-911



Garmin inReach Mini 2

garmin.com/en-US/p/765374